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A PRE-COLONIAL HISTORY OF MALAWI

by John G. Pike.

Introduction.

THE missionary and colonial period of Malawi's¹ history covers the relatively short period of a century and in time this will no doubt tend to be considered as an episode—albeit an important one—in the history of the country. The historical record of this period is considerable, and as a result historical studies have tended to concentrate on these conventional data. This paper attempts to outline the history of Malawi from pre-historic times to the latter end of the nineteenth century when the colonial period began. It is by way of an experiment; to combine the oral traditions of the people of Malawi with what historical evidence may exist together with the not inconsiderable amount of archeological, ethnological and sociological work carried out in recent years. A large part of this paper is therefore based on conjecture and deduction and it should be considered as a historical reconstruction of what probably happened rather than in a definitive way.

Prehistory.

The Lake Nyasa basin with its high borderlands forms a favourable area for human settlement. The north-south oriented watersheds on either side of the lake must also have afforded an important route for migrating peoples from East Africa to Rhodesia and the high plateaux of South Africa from the earliest times.

Primitive man succeeded in mastering his environment by adapting his culture to it and it was only in this way that he was able to establish and maintain himself in spite of environmental changes. The direct effects of climate upon man are most clearly seen during the Pleistocene period in Europe, where the successive advance and retreat of the Ice Ages determined his movements. In the same way, but on a lesser scale, man in east central Africa was affected by alternating periods of wet and dry climate—known as pluvials and inter-

1. W is a sound closely resembling a *v* and not unlike a *b* and for this reason early records refer to Malawi as *Maravi* and the people as *Maraves* and similarly *Chevas* for *Cewa*.

pluvials—during the same period.¹ Attempts have been made to correlate these periods with the advance and retreat of glaciation in higher latitudes, although there is some controversy on this subject.² Archeological work has shown a sequence of pluvials and inter-pluvials and these have now assumed a stratigraphical and prehistorical significance over the greater part of Africa. Dr. L. S. B. Leakey³ has recognised four pluvial periods in East Africa: the Kageran, Kamasian, Kanjeran and Gamblian, followed by two wet phases known as Makalin and Nakuran. The first of the pluvial periods is ascribed to the Lower Pleistocene, and the fourth to the Upper Pleistocene; while the Makalian wet phase is considered as epi-Pleistocene and the Nakuran as Recent. It is, however, only from about the Kanjeran-Gamblian inter-pluvial that true man appeared, replacing earlier man-like species—Neanderthal and Rhodesian man.

The earliest evidence of man's presence in the Malawi region dated from this period.⁴ These people were probably of proto-Australiod stock, that is, having features in common with the Australian aborigine, that evolved directly in Africa, from early Pithecanthropus stock. The main cultures of this period throughout east and central Africa have been termed the Sangoan and Fauresmith.⁵ The former was confined to the moister woodland savannah regions whereas the Fauresmith appears to have been characteristic of the drier regions extending from East African to the Cape. The remains of Sangoan culture have been found in a number of localities over a wide area of central Africa and its focus appears to have been the equatorial forests of the Congo basin. It is possible that the Sangoan spread southwards and eastwards from this point, but it is equally likely that this culture, more adaptive than its contemporary Fauresmith, was an expression of man's need to adapt himself to a changing ecology of retreating and advancing forests at this time. The Sangoan culture exhibits three main variants in central Africa⁶ of which the Laungwa

1. Sonia Cole, *The Prehistory of East Africa*, (1954), p. 34.

2. G. C. Simpson, 'Further studies in world climate, *Q. Jour. Roy Met. Soc.*, 1957.

3. 'The climatic sequence of the Pleistocene in Africa', *11e Congres Panafricain de Pre'histoire*, (1952), *Paris*, p. 293.

4. J. G. Pike, 'The prehistorical climates of Nyasaland', *Nyasaland Journal* (13), 1960).

5. J. D. Clark *The Prehistory of Southern Africa*, (1959) p. 144.

6. *ibid*, p. 145.

is characteristic of the eastern regions, our immediate area of interest.

On raised beaches of Lake Nyasa in the Karonga area and near Monkey Bay, middle stone age implements belonging to this variant have been recovered¹. These are mainly made from quartz and comprise forms of simple sub-triangular unifaced flakes, based on a prepared disc core. Diminutive hand axes occur but these are rare. The nature of the environment in which this culture flourished—moderately thick woodland and some forest—indicates that the numerous pick-like tools and un-specialised scrapers are most certainly carpenters tools for making implements and receptacles from wood and bark. These cultural remains are mainly confined to favourable areas of river valleys or the lake shore, but with the onset of wetter conditions of the Gamblian pluvial there appears to have been a dispersal to the watershed areas. The increasing aridity at the close of this period brought about more permanent migrations of hunting groups out of areas that could no longer support them and into contact with other groups of peoples. That there was some retreat into former favourable areas there is no doubt, but these people had improved their techniques to such an extent that they were enabled to inhabit areas that were possibly marginal in earlier arid phases. This cultural contact with other groups and the need for adaptation to harsher conditions led to fundamental changes and this period, the post-Gamblian inter-pluvial, saw the manufacture of more specialised tools such as effective arrowheads and knives, which in turn led to the specialised cultures of the Later Stone Age.²

These specialised cultures that evolved directly out of the Middle Stone Age were to usher in the Later Stone Age that coincided approximately with the Makalian wet phase, approximately equivalent to the Atlantic period in Europe and probably lasted from about 5,000 B.C. into historical times. The age was one of regional specialisation on a large scale and in the north-eastern regions of central Africa and southern Tanganyika the Nachikufan culture has been identified as the main culture type. This culture, like its contemporary Wilton of the drier open country elsewhere, was essentially microlithic.

1. J. D. Clark, 'Prehistory in Nyasaland', *Nyasaland Journal* (9), 1956.

2. J. D. Clark, *op. cit.*, 1959.

Remains of Nachikufan man in Malawi have been found at Hora Mountain in the Mzimba district¹ and his distinctive geometric art may be seen on many rock faces and shelters scattered throughout the country from Mzimba in the north to Mikolongwe in the south. These paintings are probably the earliest known paintings in Southern Africa. The Nachikufan people were probably a hunting people, adapted to a woodland forest environment, and the numerous grindstones, mullers, pestles and mortars found show that vegetable foods formed an important part of their diet. The skeletal remains of a man and a woman found at Hora show features that bear only a slight resemblance to present day Africans. The remains of the man show no Negro or Bushmanoid features but rather the high rounded head and pointed chin of people of Caucasian stock. The remains of the woman however exhibit features that characterise both Negro and Bushman stocks although in this case the brain case is elongated, as in the man. These people were therefore not typical Bushmen but seem to have combined other physical features in their make-up, notably those associated with the existing people of the Horn of Africa of Hamitic stock.²

The term Hamitic as used at present includes such people in North Africa as the Berber and Taureg, and in the north-east, the Somali and Galla, the former being known as the northern Hamites and the latter as the eastern Hamites. Modern terminology refers to the former as simply Berber and to the latter as Cushite.³ The term Cushitic is now used to describe the non-negroid peoples of north eastern African who do not speak Semitic languages and who are comprised in four zones; northern, central, eastern and south-western. The Cushitic peoples probably entered Africa from Asia through the Horn and the first trace of their occupation in East Africa dates from about 5,000 B.C. In East Africa their settlement was confined to the course of the rift valley from Lake Rudolf to Tanganyika and identified by a distinctive Capsian culture. These Cushitic peoples intermixed with the the Negroes, with the result that successive waves of Cushitic immigrants can be distinguished by the greater or lesser amount of negroid physical characteristics which they show.

1. J. D. Clark, op. cit., 1956.

2. J. D. Clark, op. cit., (1956).

3. J. H. Greenberg, *Studies in African Linguistic Classification*; reprinted from S.W. *Anthrop.*, New Haven, 1955, p. 51-55.

The proposition that the ancient civilizations of Africa are the civilizations of the Cushites,¹ who were pastoral 'Europeans', has dominated African studies for some time. The idea of negro Africa as modified by the influence of quasi-European or Caucasian intruders is clearly no more than an extrapolation from the situation which has existed in very recent times. Although Africa has certainly received major cultural imports from time to time, the archaeological record suggests, on the whole, continuous indigenous development rather than a succession of external contacts; and the palaeontological record makes it clear that people of Caucasoid type, so far from being invaders were resident, at least in East Africa, from the earliest times.²

The origin of the Negro is not known but it has been held that he originated somewhere in southern Asia and occupied parts of India, Malaysia, Indonesia and some of the Pacific Islands. Certainly there is some evidence to support this³ but the distinctive negro type with its bridgeless nose, thick and everted lips and prognathism, separates it physically from other races. An origin in tropical Africa would appear to be probable, although it should be realised that the origin of the Negro is far from certain. There is a certain amount of historical evidence of his existence in north-east Africa from Egyptian slate palettes dating back to 3,000 B.C. while burials at Khartoum suggest a date of approximately 10,000 B.C.⁴ From ethnological evidence at present available it is possible to suggest that the Negro arose somewhere in central or east Africa, and moved into the Horn at a time when conditions were more favourable than they are today. Here was their main concentration until they were displaced by the Cushitic peoples who began to push them westwards across the continent to the Guinea coast, which has now become the home of the true Negro.

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1. C. G. Seligman, *'Races of Africa'*, (3rd Ed.) 1957. Oxford.
 2. C. Wrigley, 'Economic Prehistory of Africa', *Jour. Afr. Hist.*, (1960-1) 189.
 3. The negro is characterised by having a sickle-shaped red blood cell and other ethnic groups which have mixed with them show a varying amount of sickling according to the amount of negro blood. The occurrence of sickle-cells in India has been demonstrated thus lending support to this theory. (See G. W. B. Huntingford in *History of East Africa*, (1963), p. 64).
 4. Huntingford, *op. cit.* 1963.

The Bantu Migrations.

Some five thousand years ago Africa was already inhabited by four main racial types recognised as indigenous in historical times; the Bushmen, Pygmies, Cushites and Negroes. The Cushites had largely displaced the Negroes towards the west and to the south the Bushmen ranged in small bands over the more open, drier country. In the humid recesses of the Congo basin there remained the ancestors of the modern Pygmy, who it might be added, were physically taller than their modern decedents.¹ It is out of these four main stocks that the majority of present-day Africans occupying the sub-continent, the Bantu-speaking people, are decended.

The Bantu do not constitute genetically an ethnic group, for there is no homogeneity of physical type among them. They may be considered as a linguistic group united by two outstanding features not found in other African languages. The first is the grouping together of words in classes distinguished by pairs of singular and plural prefixes such as UMUntu 'person', plural ABAntu 'people'. The second feature is the agreement of adjectives, pronouns and verbs with the noun to which they refer by means of a prefix derived from the class-prefix of the governing noun.²

Linguistic studies show that the Eastern and Western Sudanic languages, originally from a common Negro stock, have been growing away from each other for at least five thousand years.³ The Bantu languages spoken today over most of the sub-continent are very similar and can be related to the Western Sudanic group of languages. Because of this great similarity it has been suggested that the Bantu nuclear area must have been a relatively small one and this has been shown to be a region in Cameroun on the edge of the equatorial forest.⁴

Archeaologists today are sure that the first cultivation of crops and domestication of animals occurred in south-west Asia, more precisely among the people of the Jordan Valley during the eighth millenium, and spread into Africa during

1. R. Oliver & F. D. Fage, *'A Short History of Africa'*, (1962), p. 21.

2. G. W. B. Huntingford, *op. cit.*, (1963), p. 80.

3. Oliver and Fage, *ibid.* p. 29.

4. G. P. Murdock, *'Africa—Its Peoples and Culture History'*, (1959) p. 271.

the earliest phase of the Neolithic. However, it is possible that there was an original and independent invention of agriculture in the sub-Saharan region. Many of the crops of this region—the millets (*Sorghum*, *Eleusine*, and *Pennisetum*), simsim (*Sesamum*) and certain pulses (*Cajanus* spp.) are certainly indigenous. Murdock¹ has asserted that agriculture in tropical Africa was initiated in the upper Niger area in about 5,000 B.C. by the ancestors of the Mande-speaking peoples and that they took this step independently, if somewhat later than, the peoples of south-west Asia. Whereas criticism may be made of Murdock's more specific hypotheses, his main contention of the antiquity of African agriculture is well founded. Not only is the continent the original home of a large number of cultivated plants, but some at least of these species have proliferated into a great many different varieties.²

Although the problem of the origin of African agriculture may remain conjectural, for there is little proof, the techniques and plants of the savannah sub-Saharan region were of little value in the humid forest regions to where the Bantu-speaking peoples first spread. Two events, however, occurring at about the same time close to the beginning of the Christian era, were to provide the necessary impetus. The first was the knowledge of iron working, the technique having been mediated by the people of Meroe in Upper Nubia to the west coast regions; and the second was the introduction into Africa of certain forest plants that have their origin in south-east Asia. These were the banana, at least two species of yam (*Dioscorea* spp.) and the cocoyam (*Colocasia*). It is more than probable that these were brought to Africa by people of Indonesian stock who sailed the ancient Sabbean route from Malaysia to East Africa and whose descendants may be seen today in the present population of Madagascar.

The manner in which these Asian food plants were introduced into the interior is based mainly on conjecture, and the diffusion of these plants is far from clear. Murdock³ sees them as having been transmitted from Uganda to the west coast via the sub-Saharan savannah lands and there adopted by the nuclear Bantu who migrated with them to the humid

1. *ibid.* p. 222.

2. C. Wrigley, *op. cit.*, (1960), p. 192.

3. *op. cit.*, (1959).

forests of the Congo Basin and later emerged into the savannah lands of south and east Africa. This hypothesis is not without its difficulties. The type of country into which the Bantu emerged from the Congo is similar to the sub-Saharan savannah and, having inevitably lost their savannah crops, they would have had to re-acquire them. Murdock resolves this by postulating that groups first pressed eastwards to Uganda where they obtained sorghum and millet from the Cushites and passed them on, together with the latter's monarchical system, to their brethren in the Congo who were then able to continue with their occupation of the savannah lands lying to the south.

One of the implications of Murdock's theory is the complete absence of agriculture in south-east Africa prior to the Bantu migrations. There are, however, definite traces of pre-historic vege-culture by Nachikufan man in Malawi and elsewhere. Furthermore, the speed with which these plants were diffused would point to the fact that the indigenous population were already familiar with a similar form of agriculture. Developing this theme, Wrigley¹ has postulated that the spread of these plants could also have been through the Zambezi valley and that they did not possess the revolutionary significance assigned to them. On the other hand it has been suggested that the Indonesian's circumnavigated the Cape and brought these plants directly to the west coast.² This would appear improbable from the nature of their primitive vessels that were dependent upon the monsoon for their sailing habits, for once south of the Mocambique Channel, the monsoon gives way to the south-east trade wind.

Whatever the true precedence of these exotic food plants were to the Bantu in south-east Africa, the one asset that the Bantu are known to have possessed over the indigenous population was the iron spear. Thus the spread of the Bantu can be more easily explained as a dominant minority skilled in hunting with the iron spear, constantly attracting new adherents, and the ascendancy of military organisation and ethos that arose from the full exploitation of the spear.³

1. Wrigley, *op. cit.*, (1960) p. 198.

2. Oliver and Fage, *op. cit.*, (1962).

3. Wrigley, *ibid.*, p. 198.

The main concentration of early Bantu settlers appears to have been the southern Congo basin in the region of the Kasai River and it was from this secondary nuclear area that they spread southwards and eastwards. In the course of this dispersal, early Negroid stocks and the Bushmen were either absorbed or displaced, the survivors retreating to the recesses of the Congo Forests or the south-western deserts. To the east the Cushite's at first held their own against the Bantu settlers, but in time considerable inter-mixing took place and it was from the Cushite's that groups of Bantu probably obtained cattle and adopted pastoralism together with a patrilineal system of descent and social organisation. At the time of the Bantu incursion into East Africa it is probable that the Cushites had extended themselves well into southern Africa and it is thought that inter-marriage between them and the Bushmen produced the separate tribe of Hottentots. It is also probable that they, rather than the Bantu, were the first miners of Rhodesia. The evidence of the Hora burials in Malawi point to a people of predominantly Cushitic make-up and Al-Masudi, the Arab geographer who died in 956, describes the people of the south-eastern interior as *zeng* and are said to be 'a tribe of Abyssinians who migrated there recently.'¹ In time however these people were absorbed by the more rapidly expanding Bantu cultivators and hunters, so that today Cushitic physical features and cultural traits survive among many Bantu-speaking groups of south-east Africa.

The Coming of Malawi

Although groups of Bantu may possibly have moved southwards into Rhodesia as early as A.D. 600 there does not appear to have been a concerted movement into the Malawi region earlier than about the fifteenth century. The high tsetse free watersheds may possibly have afforded a route for migrating pastoralists but it was not the type of country in which such people would linger, in contrast to the high grass covered plateaux south of the Zambesi. Rather it is the country of the cultivator, wooded savannah with broad grass covered '*dambos*' or open swale-like depressions, and suited to the 'slash and burn' method of agriculture.

1. *Al-Masudi*, trans. and ed. by A. C. Barbier de Meynard and P. de Courteille, 9 vols, Paris, (1861).

Thus the original inhabitants, the Batwa, were largely left undisturbed to rove the country in small hunting bands and were present in some numbers in Malawi well into the 17th century.¹ The Batwa appear to have been negroid, perhaps even pygmoid, people, very black in colour, often squat and swarthy in appearance. Their origin is obscure but they appear to be connected with a similar present group known as the Bergdama in South West Africa, possibly indicating their former greater extent over southern Africa. Today isolated groups of Batwa still survive in parts of central Africa. The term Batwa is a general Bantu one but these people are known more specifically in Malawi as the Kafula, the prefix *ka*—denoting smallness and *fula* meaning either to ‘take out’ or ‘to dig a hole’. They lived, according to some accounts, a nomadic life without building more than grass shelters, or lived in antbear holes and caves. Tradition also asserts that the Kafula possessed bows and arrows tipped with an iron point. It is probable that the knowledge of iron working was passed to them through contact with an earlier group of Bantu, the Karanga.²

The Karanga moved down the western borders of Malawi to the Zambezi and then into the highlands of Rhodesia to found the empire of Mwenematupa (Monomatapa) sometime during the fifteenth century. From this Karanga host numerous small groups broke away before it crossed the Zambezi River and these settled in the central and northern regions of Malawi. These people are remembered in Malawi tradition as being tall, well built people and who bored the lobes of their ears. They owned cattle and were also cultivators and possessed well made broad bladed spears. They are referred to as the Katanga, Pule or Lenda and it has been suggested that Katanga is a corruption of Karanga.³ From all accounts they lived in villages and scattered huts and were renowned as elephant hunters, and it is in this connexion that their heavy, broad bladed spears (*nkalamanja*) are remembered in certain spirit mimes (*nyau*) of the Malawi people today. Their old village sites can be identified by the fact that they ground their grain

1. W. H. J. Rangeley, ‘The earliest inhabitants of Nyasaland’, *Nyasaland Journal* 16 (ii), 1963.

2. *ibid.*

3. *ibid.*

in grooves in great boulders and on solid rock, whereas later groups of Bantu used smaller and portable grindstones¹.

After a succession of engagements with the Malawi tribes these people were displaced southwards and Rangeley² has suggested that they are identifiable with the Zimba who appeared in the Zambezi valley at the close of the 16th century. Recent research has however established the Zimba to be a branch of the Malawi group³ and it is more than probable that the Makaranga segments were absorbed, rather than displaced by the later immigrant groups. From the traditional description it is possible that these people may have been of Cushitic origin or people who had had long contact with them, rather than an off-shoot of the Makaranga.

Sometime during the 16th century a group of Bantu cultivators entered the country to the north-west of Lake Nyasa. Today the descendants of these people occupy the greater part of Malawi and parts of adjacent territories, having divided themselves into approximately eight groups, known today as the Cewa, Nyanja, Mang'anja, Ntumba, Mbo, Chipeta, Zimba and Nsenga. The country eventually settled by this cluster extended southward from the Dwangwa River to the Zambezi River and far to the west in what is now Zambia and Mocambique. All these people speak dialects of the same language, the standard, written form of which has become known as Nyanja (*ciNyanja*). This designation, the specific reference of which is to the dialect spoken on the south-western shores of Lake Nyasa, has arisen largely by accident. Either Cewa or Malawi would have been more appropriate—Cewa because of the numerical preponderance of this division; or Malawi because the so-called Nyanja speakers are descendants of a tribe or federation of tribes of this name and referred to in earlier records as the Maravi, Maraves.⁴

The Malawi people affirm that their ancestors came from the north—from the Luba country (*uluwa*) in the Lake Kisale region of the lower Congo. It was the Luba who brought the

1. E. H. Lane Poole, *Native Tribes of the Eastern Province of Northern Rhodesia* (Lusaka: Govt. Printer, 1949).

2. *op. cit.*, 1963.

3. M. G. Marwick, 'History and tradition in East Central Africa through the eyes of the Northern Rhodesian Cewa' *Jour. Afri. Hist.* 4, (iii) (1963).

4. M. G. Marwick, *op. cit.*, (1963).

ideas of kingship and techniques of state organisation to their neighbours, the Lunda who were later to found a vast empire over most of Katanga and sire the kingdoms of the Bemba and Rotse.¹ This tradition conflicts however, with an equally prevalent one, particularly among the Cewa, that the Malawi tribe was created in the hot lowlands immediately south west of Lake Nyasa, an area still known specifically as Malawi. Two interpretations may be made on these conflicting accounts. Though the story of the migration from the north is presented as if it were a movement of a whole people, it could be the coming of chiefly invaders who gained control over longer established groups. This interpretation is supported by the traditional division of function between the two main Malawi matrilineal clans. The Phiri, to whom the traditional chiefs belonged, have political power; and the Banda, who may be descended from the original groups, have a close relationship with the land and are credited with the power of making rain.² Alternatively this interpretation may be but part of the overall story. A modern Cewa would be correct in asserting that his tribe had their beginnings on the south-western shores of Lake Nyasa because it was here that fission from the main Malawi host occurred, they all having previously belonged to one or another of the clans that entered as one group. Tradition also asserts that the Banda clan were part of the main migration.

According to orthodox tradition, the Malawi tribe were led away from the Congo by Mazizi Karonga, the name 'Karonga' being the title of chief in the same way as Kazembe, Jumbe etc., and possibly derived from 'kulonga', 'to gather together'. The tribe was made up principally of four clans, the Phiri, Banda, Mwali and Nkhoma.³ From their first settlement near Choma Mountain, some 10 miles north of present day Mzuzu, the Karonga despatched his son, Kanyenda Muka-

1. J. Vansina, 'South of the Congo' in *The Dawn of African History* ed. by R. Oliver, Oxford, 1961.
2. R. A. Hamilton, 'Oral Tradition: Central Africa' in *History and Archeology in Africa*. London, 1951.
3. For details of traditional history the accounts and records of Nthara, Chibambo, Sanderson, Bruwer, Cullen-Young and Rangeley have been freely consulted and where possible augmented with details recorded by the writer. All these workers preceded the writer and their writings have become comparatively well known throughout the country, with the consequence that it is now difficult to obtain independent accounts of what has been recorded.

dzula, head of the Mwali clan, in company with Kabunduli Phiri, his 'nephew', on a journey of exploration. They travelled southwards along the shores of Lake Nyasa, eventually reaching Mankhamba near the Linthipe River. This large tract of country almost uninhabited, save for small groups of Kafula, must have offered an attractive country for settlement. From Mankhamba the two explorers hastened back to Choma to report their findings, but before the tribe found time to move, Mazizi Karonga died. Under the matrilineal system of descent he was succeeded by his nephew and it was this man who led the tribe southwards in occupation driving the Kafula people before them. Among all different groups of the Malawi today one may repeatedly be told of how their forefathers 'cleared the land' of the Kafula. In time the group reached Mankhamba where Karonga made his headquarters. On the north bank of the Nadzipulu River near Ntakataka there is a small thicket, now much reduced in size, known as Malawi and it is here that the Phiri shrine of the Karonga's is still maintained.

From Mankhamba, Karonga sent his 'younger brother' (which may mean any junior matrilineal kinsman), Undi, to colonise the headwaters of the Kapoche River, an area that is now divided between Zambia and Mocambique.¹ Undi was assisted by Chimwala who went further east into the country now inhabited by the Nsenga tribe. To the north of Undi's country, over what is now the central region of Malawi and the eastern province of Zambia, Karonga divided the country between Culu and Mkanda, although it is possible that Mkanda was sometime subordinate to Undi.² Mwase Kasungu is now the most powerful of the chiefdoms in this region although the rise to power of this chiefdom probably came at a later date, a rise that is attributed to the enterprise and courage of its founders, its geographical position on a main trading route and the prestige arising from successful resistance to the Ngoni, and later, from an alliance with them.³ These groups came to be known as Cewa or sometimes Chipeta ('people of the long grass'), although by the early 19th century Portuguese explorers were referring to Undi as the chief of the Malawi and Mkanda as the most powerful of the Cewa chiefs.⁴

1. Marwick, *op. cit.*, p. 379.

2. *ibid.*, p. 381.

3. Unpublished notes by T. D. Thompson quoted by Marwick, *op. cit.*

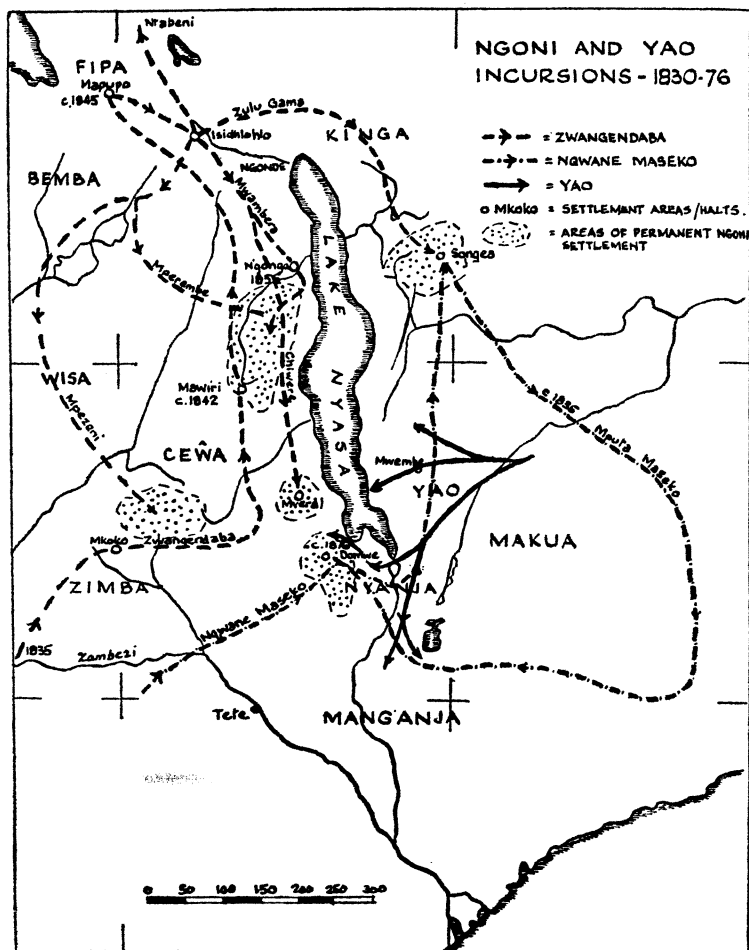
4. See page 32.

Whilst these colonising movements were taking place towards the watershed areas to the west, other kinsmen of Karonga were moving away from Mankhamba in a southerly direction, groups that were to become the Nyanja and Mang'anja people. Kapwhiti appears to have been the leader of this movement and he moved in the first instance to Mbewe-wa-Nyangu, a twin-peaked hill overlooking the upper Shire River near present day Kalembo. At a time that we know to have been earlier than 1616,¹ Kapwhiti in company with his kinsman, Lundu Phiri, set out down the Shire Valley. Kapwhiti settled at Malawi-waKapwhiti on the Wankurumadzi River whilst Lundu Phiri went on down into the hot, low-lying Shire Valley to settle at Mbewe on the lower reaches of the Mwanza River, some 15 miles south of present day Chikwawa. The relationship between Kapwhiti and Lundu is obscure but tradition holds that Lundu was junior to Kapwhiti.

In 1616 Gaspar Bocarro describes Kapwhiti as the great chief of the country,² subordinate to the Karonga, yet forty years later, the Portuguese at Tete were describing Lundu in the same terms.³ Bocarro is more likely to be correct as he passed through both Lundu's and Kapwhiti's settlements⁴ whereas the Portuguese at Tete would tend to refer to Lundu as paramount as he controlled the area nearest to them. Certain traditions are recorded⁵ that Kapwhiti and Lundu were both subject to Undi 'the leader of all Malawi'. If Undi had succeeded the Karonga to this title it is not clear, if this is true, why he did not assume the same appellation. As Undi, Kapwhiti and Lundu all belonged to the Phiri matriclan tracing descent to the Karonga it is more probable that the latter two were independent of Undi.

At Mbewe-wa-Mitengo, the Lundu established his court with his rainmakers and a strong following of sub-chiefs and people. At first the settlement was probably small and his

1. The date of Gaspar Bocarro's journey. See R. A. Hamilton 'The Route of Gaspar Bocarro from Tete to Kilwa in 1616', *Nyasaland Journal* (7) (ii) 7-14, 1954.
2. *ibid.*, p. 10
3. G. M. Theal, '*Records of South-East Africa*' (9 vols.) (London: for the Govt. of the Cape Colony, 1898- 1903, 7,290 ff.
4. W. H. J. Rangeley, 'Bocarro's Journey', *Nyasaland Journal* 7 (ii) p. 15-23.
5. A. W. R. Duly, 'The Lower Shire District' *Nyasa. Jour.* (16), 1963.



people were confined to the level lands lying to the west and adjacent to the Shire River. Towards the end of the 18th century however, the Lundu of that time began expanding southwards by despatching sub-chiefs to settle new lands to the south. Mlolo and Tengani settled near the confluence of the Shire and Ruwus Rivers and Dobvu and Monyo travelled as far south as the Zambezi as the advance guard against the Tonga peoples under Makombe. At a later date, further sub-chieftainships arose from the appointment of priests or custodians of the rain shrine of Mbona, a once highly successful rainmaker attached to Lundu's court.¹

The southern vanguard of the Malawi people led by Lundu Phiri had taken the name of Mang'anja, a title that throws an interesting light on the origin of the name Malawi. The name Mang'anja has been described as pertaining to the people of the river or lake (*nyasa, nyanja*) but enquiry in the Mang'anja area does not lend support to this derivation.² From the 17th century onwards, the Portuguese record the people of the Shire region above the confluence as Mang'anja who called the river *nyanja* and to this day Mang'anja as a territorial designation exists in the name of Manganja da Costa near Quelimane. There is no trace of any link between the name Mang'anja and any body of water and it is apparent that the name extended far beyond the modern borders of the country. It has been suggested that Mang'anja might be translated as "the people iron furnace country" from *ng'anjo* (smelting furnace). Neither lake nor river has anything like the prominence in Mang'anja tradition that iron has. It has been postulated that the word Malawi refers to the red flame like shimmer of rippled lake water under a low sun (*lawi*—flames) thus linking the name with the lake background of Nyanja. Certain hill names well to the south of the lake do not support this and Price³ has put forward a more economical argument based on his derivation of the word Mang'anja; that Malawi may be translated as the "land of flames", with its obvious connections with the smelting furnaces. Thus Mang'anja and Malawi would not be two separate areas but would overlap and unite, just as the language of the people and

1. *ibid.*

2. T. Price, 'The meaning of Mang'anja', *Nyasa. Jour.* (16), 1963.

3. T. Price, *op. cit.*, 1963.

their bonds of clanship run throughout the country covered by either of these terms.

The final stream of migration resulting from fission at Mankhamba was that led by Kanyenda, although he may well have been the first to break away. On leaving Mankhamba, Kanyenda, accompanied once again by Kabunduli, set out northwards to occupy the lake shore country in the region of Nkhota Nkoto, on the fringes of the Bana swamp. Kanyenda settled at Nkhungu, some 25 miles north of Nkhota-Nkoto, where the iron stool of the first Kanyenda may still be seen. Kabunduli, on the other hand, was despatched further northwards to the Luweya River, an area of thick forest flanking the Vipya Mountains. The main purpose in despatching Kabunduli to this area was, so it is said, to guard the northern approaches against the incursions of the Timbuka people, a closely related tribe that were beginning to move eastward from the Luangwa watershed over the Vipya Mountains.¹

But Kabunduli appears to have been a man of diffident nature and was content to limit his area immediately surrounding his settlement on the Luweya River above Chiwandama Falls. Consequently, members of the Zumara, Munthali and Siska clans of the Timbuka moved over the mountains and settled to the north of him along the lake shore without any regular arrangement of land apportionment and tribute was not exacted from them.

This area today, from the Dwambadzi River in the south to Ruarwe in the north, is inhabited by people of the Tonga tribe² and although their tribal identity is now considered obvious by themselves and by others, all available evidence points to a heterogenous origin.³ The beginnings of the tribe are comparatively recent, not much later than the latter decades of the 18th century, and it appears that they are an amalgamation of four groups, the followers of Kabunduli, the Nyaliwanga (a clan of Timbuka), the Kapunda Banda who are a Malawi group who supposedly broke away from Mwase Kasungu, and the Mankambira group, who were more recent immigrants from

1. S. Y. Nthara in *'Some Notes on the History of the Nkamanga—Tumbuka People*, Blantyre, 1935, by A. Cullen Young.

2. A. distinct tribal group from the Tonga of the Zambezi Valley.

3. J. van Velsen, *'Notes on the History of the Lakeside Tonga of Nyasaland'*, *African Studies*, 18 (3), 1959, 105-115.

the eastern shores of Lake Nyasa. The true precedence of the Kabunduli and Kapunda Banda groups is far from clear, and present day enquiry is hampered because these two groups are competing for political and executive authority and there is a tendency for each group to give historical validity to the present day situation. Some traditions suggest that Kabunduli entered the country independently from the north¹ whereas another associates Kabunduli with Mlowoka, the leader of an immigrant group from the east of Lake Nyasa who established his hegemony over the Timbuka people in the latter part of the 18th century.² The account followed in this case, that Kabunduli was part of the main Malawi group, would seem to be more likely as Kabunduli's clan name is Phiri, the matriclan of the Malawi leaders.

Malawi history, as opposed to deductions and conjecture based on traditional accounts outlined in the foregoing pages, begins with the record of the Portuguese, who, after the discovery of the sea route to India at the close of the 15th century, established settlements on the southern periphery of the country. The first references to the inhabitants of the country appear in the record of the overland journey undertaken by Gaspar Bocarro from Tete to Kilwa on the coast in 1616.³ Because Bocarro was motivated by considerations of local politics and the fact that this journal was compiled by a namesake of his some twenty years after the journey, misgivings have been expressed on the authenticity of some of the crucial passages. This as may be, but he named places several of which are indentifiable today as place names and by the present inhabitants. He also records the names Nyanja and Mang'anja, even if in the wrong contexts. There is little doubt therefore, that by the beginning of the 17th century, the country at the southern limits of Lake Nyasa was already occupied by the Malawi peoples. If the Malawi tribes represent the eastern vanguard of the Luwa expansion, which would appear probable, it is possible that they entered the country sometime during the mid-16th century.

A systematic report by the Jesuit priest Baretto in 1667⁴ confirms the occupation of Malawi by the various Malawi

1. *ibid.*, p. III.

2. T. Cullen Young, *op. cit.*, 1932, p. 92.

3. R. A. Hamilton, *op. cit.*, 1954.

4. 'Report upon the State and Conquest of the Rivers of Cuama' (1667), trans. in Theal, *Records of South East Africa* 3, 415-19.

tribes and records that the Malawi people through 'Rundo (*Lundu*) the second person in the empire of Maravi' ruled the country on the north bank of the Zambezi for a distance of '200 leagues up the river from Quilimane'. He also reported that the Malawi traded with the Portuguese 'in ivory, much iron, many slaves and *machiras*, which are cotton cloths in great demand in Mokaranga (Monomatapa);' and that the Malawi empire was 'governed by its emporer, named Caronga'¹ These records give the impression that, when they were written, the Malawi were a well organised tribe or federation of related tribes, dominating a large part of the country north of the Zambezi. Although Baretto mentions that the Malawi dominated the Makua peoples to the east no mention is made of the probable extent of their settlement to the west. It was only in the latter part of the 18th century that this was found to be in the region of the Luangwa River. From these early records it is possible to infer that the Malawi confederation of tribes probably dominated an area north of the Zambezi that spread from the Gurue' highlands inland from Quelimane in the east, to the Luangwa River in the west and reached as far north as the Dwangwa River. Beyond this river lay the country of the Timbuka who, although speaking a language that is similar to the Malawi tribes, are a distinct group that probably migrated into the area after the main Malawi incursion.

Over a hundred years later the Portuguese were penetrating Malawi territory in an effort to discover a route across the continent to their possessions on the west coast and at the same time to tap the trade that existed between Katanga and the coast. The copper deposits of this region were probably being worked by the eighteenth century and possibly much earlier; and it was almost certainly through the control which they established over this area and its adjacent saltpans that the Lunda Kazembes' built up a power which came to rival and eventually overshadow the parent Luwa empire of Mwata Yamvo in the Upper Congo. Their capital, in the Luapula valley, became the objective of these Portuguese expeditions who had perceived that Katanga was the pivot of central African trade at this time. The most notable of these expeditions was that led by de Lacerda e Almeida, a Brazilian mathematician, that started from Tete in July,

1. *ibid.*, p. 480.

1798.¹ Travelling north from Tete Lacerda crossed the Dzalan-nyama Range into present day Malawi some miles to the east of Fort Manning (Mchinji) and, after crossing the Bua and Rusa Rivers, headed north-westwards towards the Luangwa. In this area he was in the country of 'King Mocanda (*Mkanda*) the most powerful in people, and dreaded Maravi chief of these parts'², and complains bitterly of the way in which he was delayed and impoverished by the Malawi who levied tribute on the slightest pretext. After leaving Mkanda's country, de Lacerda recorded that another tribe 'the Mutumbuca' were settled in the area. This is the first historical reference to the Timbuka tribe. de Lacerda died near Kazembe's capital and the Kazembe assured his deputy, Father Pinto, that a subsequent expedition would be received and facilities provided to carry on westwards to the coast.

It was not until 1831 that a further expedition was mounted, led by Major J. M. C. Monteiro, and charged to establish trade relations with Kazembe, if possible by treaty. This expedition too ended in the failure of its true object; Kazembe merely delaying them sufficiently to strip them of their trade goods in daily tributes. The remnants of the expedition returned to Tete after suffering incredible hardship and privation, all of which was faithfully recorded by the second-in command, Captain A. C. P. Gamitto. This journal³ provides the first complete description of the Malawi people of this region at this time. Gamitto appears to have been a modest man and his remarkable objective description of the culture and economy of the Malawi and Timbuka tribes is far superior to anything written on this part of Africa up until the end of the century.

Gamitto applies the name Malawi to the people of the area south of the present Zambia-Mocambique border who were ultimately subject to Undi, but north of the Mchinji hills the people are referred to as the Cewa and subject to either Mkanda or Mwase. This political separation of the Malawi and Cewa was not associated with much cultural differentiation, although

1. R. F. Burton, 'Lacerda's Journey to the Cazembe in 1798' in *Lands of Cazembe*, London, 1873.

2. *ibid.*, p. 48.

3. A. C. P. Gamitto, '*O Muata Cazembe*', (Lisbon: Imprensa Nacional, 1854) trans. by I. Cunnison as *King Kazembe* and published by Junta de Investigacoes do Ultramar, Lisbon, 1960.

Gamitto notes¹ that the Cewa were more kindly disposed toward the expedition than Undi's people. Sometime prior to these expeditions of the early nineteenth century it is apparent that the 'empire' of Malawi seems to have differentiated and their political unity decayed.

The Timbuka and the Nkamanga Chieftdom.

Some time after the main Malawi migration into central and southern Malawi, an associated group of clans without any centralised chieftdom began to move into the northern regions of Malawi and occupied the country from the southern flanks of the Nyika plateau in the north to Dwangwa River in the south. These people were described by Gamitto² as inhabiting areas further south than this but referred to them as 'colons' in the Cewa country. The tribal name Timbuka appears to refer to one particular clan of these people as other clans of prominence are the Hewe, Chimaliro, Munthali, Phoka, Senga, Zumara, Nyaliwanga and Siska and today geographical features bearing these names may be found to indicate the areas of original settlement. Nyaliwanga, for instance, is said to describe the Vipya Highland country and today the dominant clan of this area, the Kaunda, will often be found to bear the name Nyaliwanga as well.

From a study of clan names among present-day Timbuka³ there are groups that can be traced to the period commencing in the latter decades of the 18th century and they have been connected not only with the arrival of a new element in the country but with a marked political change, the centralisation of power in one hand and the birth of a chieftdom. These people crossed Lake Nyasa from the east and entered the country surrounding the Nyika and Vipya highlands settled by the Timbuka. Whether or not this group of people intended settling permanently or whether they came to hunt for ivory for trade is not known. The leader of the party had come to be known as Mlowoka ('he who crossed over'), but it is certain that his original name was Katumbi. He placed Mwamlowe at the mouth of the Rukuru River and Mwahenga in the

1. *ibid*, p. 142.

2. *ibid*, p. 147.

3. T. Cullen Young, *op. cit.*, 1932.

Henga Valley as sub-chiefs and moving into the area beyond the Njakwa Gorge near present day Rumpi, he placed Sekuru at Chikwawa on the right bank of the Runyina River. Katumbi himself proceeded further west and moved down into the Luangwa Valley. The placing of these sub-chiefs at strategic points on the route to the sources of ivory in the Luangwa valley may indicate that Katumbi was endeavouring to set up a trade route into the interior. Whether or not the settlement of these sub-chiefs took place at this time, tradition agrees that these newcomers came without any show of force, and it is possible that it was not until some time later, when his personal prestige had put him in a position to assume authority, that he divided the country among his companions.

These newcomers represented a type of person considerably more sophisticated than the Timbuka and were probably originally members of one of the southern Tanganyika Bantu tribes, the Beni, Kinga, etc., who were organised in a patrilineal system and probably had an earlier contact with the coast from their geographical position astride the Kazembe-Zanzibar trade route. They were ivory traders and found themselves among people who used ivory for domestic utensils quite ignorant of its value to the outside world. Sekuru, the associate or relative of Katumbi, who settled just west of Rumpi, succeeded in establishing his authority to such an extent that the Chikula-mayembe chiefdom which his heir inaugurated stood for a form of centralised chiefdom not previously known in the region. To ensure the continuance of the chiefdom in the hands of the newcomers their patrilineal system was imposed upon the Timbuka who were a matrilineal people.

From their earlier contacts with the markets of the East Coast and previous connexions on the east coast of Lake Nyasa, ivory began to be exported in ever increasing quantities. His caravans to the coast gave employment to many Timbuka and by this time the name 'Nkamanga' was beginning to be used as a general description of northern Malawi in the coast centres. In 1850 Rebmann, a German missionary in the Mombassa area, refers to this region as Wakamanga through contact with a slave from Nkamanga.¹

Having placed themselves geographically in a most favourable position on the Nkamanga Plain, it was the Chikula-

1. T. Cullen Young, 'The Henga people of Northern Nyasaland' *Nyasaland Journal* 5, (i), 1952 p. 33.

mayembe's who appear to have risen to power over Katumbi, the leader of the group. Katumbi, after a sojourn in the Luangwa valley and at Nthaliri, to the west of the Nyika plateau, moved back to Hewe inside the present day Malawi border. His authority not only covered Hewe but adjacent territory far to the west. A further decline in Katumbi's power occurred at the time of European partition when his area was dismembered between, what was then, the British Central Africa Protectorate and Northern Rhodesia.

At the time of Chikulamayembe VI (Bambata)¹ the country of Nkamanga appears to have achieved an envious reputation as a centre of wealth and trade with the coast. To the west, across the Luangwa River, the Wemba tribe under the chieftainship of the Chitimukulu's had been growing to power through trading contacts with Kazembe. They cast covetous eyes on Nkamanga and in about 1845 an army under Chepere set out in conquest. The Nkamanga-Timbuka defeated the Wemba but their comparatively peaceful existence was soon to be over-run by the Ngoni in about 1855, and it was not until eighty years later that the Chikulamayembe and Katumbi chieftainships were revived under the Protectorate government.

The Ngonde-Nyakyusa Settlement.

Up until the early decades of the nineteenth century the Malawi scene appears to have been one of relative peace and stability, if one may discount the frequent internecine struggles between various groups. It was however to be shortly disrupted by the forays of the Yao slavers from the east and the Ngoni from the west, a disruption that was to leave a permanent mark on the country. In the north-western corner of Malawi however, in the area that today lies partly in the Karonga district of Malawi and the Tukuyu district of Tanganyika, one enclave of people succeeded in defending themselves from attack and remained little affected by outside influences up to the time of the first European visitors in the closing decades of the century. The kindred Ngonde and Nyakyusa peoples, distinct in origin from the Malawi and Timbuka peoples, inhabited this fertile area and established for themselves a degree of material well being and social development unequalled in this part of Africa.

1. T. Cullen Young, *op. cit.*, 1932.

The Nyakyusa and Ngonde tribes bear a broad cultural relationship to the Kinga, the Safwa, Pangwa, Namwanga and Nyika tribes who represent the southern vanguard of the Sukuma-Nyamwezi expansion from the inter-lacustrine regions of East Africa some 200 years ago.¹ All of them are cattle owners as well as cultivators and in most respects contrast strongly with their neighbours, the Bemba and Timbuka. All of them reckon descent in the male line and there is, moreover, a common element in all their traditions according to which the big event in their histories was the establishment of chieftainship of cattle-owning strangers who were possessors of many new techniques.² It is clear that these traditions refer to one broad stream of settlement which spread through the Iringa District and Livingstone Mountains of Tanganyika, and thence down to the Nyasa lake shore and up again on to the Mbeya plateau.

Ngonde traditions, which claim a close relationship between their own royal family (the *Kyungu's*) and that of the Namwanga chiefs, show a succession of eighteen rulers since the descent from the Kinga country (Bukinga) in the Livingstone Mountains. In the early 18th century the Kinga were ruled by Nguluwe and his two grandsons, Lwembe and Chawara. The latter two were the leaders of the migration to the lake-shore, Lwembe founding the Nyakyusa tribe through his son Mwakyusa and from Chawara are said to derive the Ngonde through his second son Maghemu, the first *Kyungu*.

The first historical record of the Nyakyusa-Ngonde peoples comes from Dr. Robert Laws who made two journeys to the north end of the lake in 1875 and 1877. No contact was made with the people until the second expedition when Laws sailed up the Mwaya creek at Itunge. His first impressions were not favourable and he describes them as 'go-nakeds', which indeed they were, 'with painted bodies and were the most savage and degraded type of African'.³ Laws did not land in the area and his description is misleading because the Nyakyusa and Ngonde were, at this time, practising one of the most advanced systems of pastoralism and cultivation in the region. This is

1. R. Oliver in '*History of East Africa*', ed. by R. Oliver and G. Mathew, Chap. VI, p. 195.
2. Monica Wilson, '*The Peoples of the Nyasa-Tanganyika Corridor*' 1948, Comm from the School of African Studies, Cape Town.
3. W. P. Livingstone, '*Laws of Livingstonia*,' 1921, p. 291.

made clear from the description of Joseph Thompson who travelled over the Poroto Mountains down to the lake shore two years after Laws' visit.¹ Thompson relates that 'it seemed a Arcadia' and remarks on the stability of the intensive cultivation of bananas, sweet potatoes and yams and, because of the heavy rainfall, they were caused to build substantial conical bamboo huts. These people afford an outstanding example of the level of comfort to which, given a favourable environment of adequate rainfall and fertile soils, African life could attain even with a simple Iron Age culture.

It has been suggested² that it was this very degree of social development and material well being, together with their remoteness, enabled them for long to repel attackers. It was however more probably the remoteness of their situation that was the deciding factor because their first encounter with predatory outsiders nearly ended in complete disaster for them. In 1877 outside influence began to spread into the area, when a group of Zanzibar Arabs set up their base near Karonga, as the theatre for a campaign of slave raiding and conquest. The Ngonde sought the protection of the first European traders in Karonga, and the small station there became the subject of Arab attacks. It was not until 1895 however, after an abortive truce, that the slavers were crushed with military action by Sir Harry Johnston.

The Ngoni Invasions.

The pre-colonial history of east-central Africa is characterised by the large scale migrations of tribal groups in a southward direction. The Ngoni migration during the mid-eighteenth century was the last large scale immigration into this region and its main direction of movement was, by contrast, from south to north. The effect of these Ngoni invasions on the people of Malawi was threefold. Firstly, there was the effect upon the small disorganised tribal groups who suddenly found themselves incorporated into one or other of the Ngoni states either as serfs or as warriors in serf regiments and trained to fight with the spear and shield. Another more sinister effect was the loosing of refugees and raiders on the regions all around the sphere of direct Ngoni settlement. It was Timbuka refugees who allied themselves to

1. J. Thompson, '*To the Central African Lakes and Back*', Vol. i, 1881, p. 267.

2. Alison Smith, in '*History of East Africa*', p. 257 (1963).

the Arabs in the Karonga area in raiding the Ngonde and elsewhere there were the notorious *rugaruga* of early travellers' accounts. Finally there were the reactions they provoked in the smaller tribes such as the lakeshore Tonga, causing them to unite and form chiefdoms to gain prestige and power by their successful resistance to them, as in the case of Mwase Kasungu.

The origins of the Ngoni migrations are to be found in northern Natal where, in the early nineteenth century, events were rapidly moving to a climax. At about this time the Boers and the Bantu in South Africa were being drawn into collision; the Europeans were pushing the frontier of their settlement northward from the Cape and were meeting increasing resistance from various tribes of Bantu settled along the eastern coast of South Africa. The Nguni had settled in Natal during the early 15th century in comparatively small chiefdoms but as their numbers and herds increased they spread into hitherto uninhabited country. The most profitable new lands lay to the south but with the arrival of the Boers, this avenue became effectively blocked. The result was that the various chiefdoms could now only expand at the expense of their neighbours, and by the first decade these strains and stresses were becoming evident whereby smaller Nguni chiefdoms had been allied or incorporated into two main groups, the Mthetwa under Dingiswayo and the Ndandwe under Zwide¹. Shaka Zulu, heir to Dingiswayo finally defeated the Ndandwe army at Umhlatusi in 1819² whereupon the Ndandwe kingdom broke up and a number of segments fled northwards out of Shaka's reach. The leader of one of these groups, Zwangendawa Jere, gathering followers of the Ntungwa, Swazi and Sutu clans, fled towards Delegoa Bay. The exact details of Zwangendawa's flight are obscure some authorities³ claiming that he only fled after Sikuyane, son of Zwide, led an abortive attack on Shaka in 1826.

Near Delegoa Bay Zwangendawa found Soshangane, a brother of Zwide and former leader of the Ndandwe army, fighting with Nxaba, another former minor chief of the Ndandwe. After a quarrel with Soshangane, Zwangendawa moved up the Limpopo Valley and thence into the country

1. Bryant A. T. '*Olden times in Zululand and Natal*'; Longmans (1929).

2. E. A. Ritter, '*Shaka Zulu*', Longmans, 1955, pp. 165-183.

3. Y. M. Chibambo '*My Ngoni of Nyasaland*', London, 1942 p. 8.

of the Makaranga in Rhodesia. By the time they reached this area the social structure of his group had already altered somewhat from the traditional Nguni structure. They called themselves Ngoni, a name derived from Nguni, but in time they came to be referred to by a wide variety of names such as the Bututa, Zowa, Landeens, Mafiti, Mavitu, Mazitu, Magwagwara, Wamachonde, Wajoja and Wapoma. The Ngoni were migrants whereas the Nguni were not. The Ngoni captured a large number of men and women of non-Nguni origin who were assimilated into the Ngoni state as individuals, whereas for the most part the Nguni states expanded by the incorporation of existing social groups as groups, not individuals, and these groups usually belonged to closely related peoples. The original Nguni founders of the Ngoni state probably numbered about one thousand in all and these people formed the core of Ngoni society. Soon however certain Nguni systems were dropped and others developed and, in effect, the system was modified to a life of migrant brigandage which the Ngoni pursued until the closing decades of the 19th century.

North of the Limpopo Zwangendawa destroyed the Kalanga and Lozi inhabitants and shortly after he moved northwards towards the Zambezi. At about this time a group under Ngwana Maseko broke away from Zwangendawa to join the latter's erstwhile comrade, Nxaba of the Nqumayo clan, who was also fleeing from the rising power of Shaka¹. In November, 1835² Zwangendawa crossed the Zambezi near Zumbo and travelled north eastwards towards the Nyasa-Luangwa watershed camping for a while at Mkoko, near present day Petauke. Meanwhile, Ngwane Maseko, carefully avoiding Zwangendawa had taken a more easterly route that brought him and his group to Dzonze hill on the Kirk Range, just south of Dedza. They did not at this time settle in this area, as they were to do more than thirty years later, but continued across the Shire valley, turned north into the country of the Yao, crossed the Rovuma River and settled in what is now the Songea District of Tanganyika.³

Moving on from Mkoko, Zwangendawa camped once again for a while in the Lilongwe area and then again at

1. There are a number of conflicting accounts of when and where the Maseko Ngoni broke away. For a discussion on these see, J. A. Barnes, *'Politics in a Changing Society'*, 1954, p. 17.
2. The exact date given as 20th November. See T. Cullen Young, op. cit. 1932, 110.
3. P. W. Gulliver, 'History of the Songea Ngoni' *Tang. Notes and Rec.* 41, 1955, 20.

Mawiri *dambo's* near present day Loudon Mission in the Mzimba district. After having been lured by reports of cattle and plunder in the country of the Fipa on the Lake Tanganyika region. Zwangendawa moved from Mawiri in about 1842 and travelled along the watershed and across the headwaters of the Luangwa to Mapupo, some 45 miles north east of Abercorn. It was here in about 1845 that Zwangendawa died and, following Nguni custom, the site of the royal kraal was vacated and the tribe moved to Isishlohlo near Tunduma. After a series of internal disputes¹ and a famine the tribe split into five separate factions under Ntaweni, Zulu Gama, Mhalho, Lufo (Mperembe) and Ntuto (Mpezeni). Ntaweni travelled to the shores of Lake Victoria and Zulu Gama headed eastward around the northern limit of Lake Nyasa to join forces with Mputa Maseko, a son of Ngwane Maseko, in the Songea area. In time the heirs of Zulu Gama drove out the Maseko Ngoni who, for the next two decades, wandered extensively over northern Mocambique through the country of the the Makua and Yao, before finally re-entering Malawi once again to settle in the Dedza area in 1876². Mperembe and Mpezeni, in the meantime, travelled south westward into the Luangwa valley and Mhalho, with Mtwalo led a group into Malawi to the north of the Mafingi Mountains, over the Nyika plateau and into the Henga Valley in about 1855. It was here that after some dissension between Mhalho, who had by this time taken the name of Mwambera (Mombera, M'mbelwa), and Mtwalo, that the former was proclaimed chief of the Ngoni segments settled in the area.

From this fertile and centrally located valley, Mwambera subjugated the Timbuka and carried out forays against neighbouring groups of Timbuka, Tonga, Cewa and on one occasion to the Karonga lake shore. After a few years Mwambera moved from his settlement at Choma and Ekwendeni and moved southwards up the Kasitu valley and was here joined by Mperembe who had earlier quit the Luangwa valley. Mpezeni did not, however, return and he travelled southwards finally to settle near Mchinji in Cewa country on the Malawi Zambia border.

1. A full account of these disputes is given by W. H. J. Rangeley, 'Mtwalo', *Nyasaland Journal* V, (i) 1952, p. 55-70.

2. *ibid.* 1952.

By the time the Ngoni reached Malawi finally to settle in 1855 there were a large number of Thonga, Karanga, Nsenga and Cewa people incorporated into their ranks. Although these groups helped to sustain the Ngoni state and power, it was the continued practice of this system that finally led to the erosion of Ngoni power by fission and rebellion by their newly incorporated Timbuka and lakeshore Tonga regiments. Emboldened by a defeat at the hands of the lakeshore Tonga led by the Mankambira and Chinyentha¹ at the mouth of the Luweya River in 1878², the Timbuka serf regiments rebelled and fled northwards to their original home in the Henga valley. Later, groups of Tonga were to break away as well. The Timbuka insurrection was finally put down by Mwambera with the help of Mwase Kasungu's Cewa, who were armed with guns, but Ngoni power in the area was already on the wane. At about this time the first Scots missionaries were making expeditions into Ngoniland who in time undermined the tribe as an effective force in the country.

The Ngoni both by the political units they formed themselves and by the reactions which they provoked in others provided a form of inoculation against what was to follow. They invaded areas that had showed little tribal unity and while the weak were annihilated the tendency was for the strong to grow stronger. They were not a party to the slave trade and having preceded the slave trade in the area to the west of Lake Nyasa they presented a formidable barrier to the Yao slave raiders who were penetrating Malawi from the east. Consequently the Yao raided the lake shore and the southern regions of Malawi, an area where the Ngoni penetration succeeded the trade. In pre-colonial Africa migration and warfare, conquest and settlement, were not always the unmitigated evils they had been painted. Sometimes, like later and larger manifestations of imperialism, they were means of communicating the achievements of the strong and successful to the weak and outpaced.³

The Yao and the Slave Trade.

Along most of the southern part of the Sultan of Zanzibar's dominions, the inland concentrations of population were

1. J. van Velsen, op. cit., 1959, p. 113.

2. Some authorities have placed this date as 1876 but Y. Chirwa in Cullen Young, op. cit. 1932 is followed in this case.

3. R. Oliver, in *'History of East Africa'* (1963), p. 211.

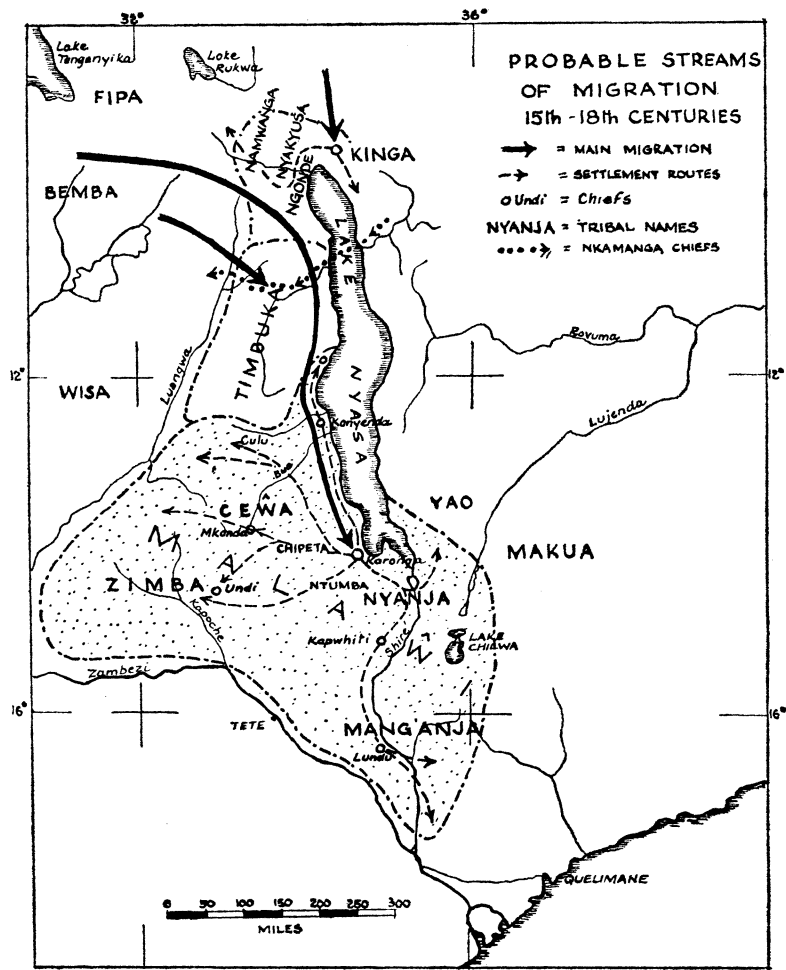
separated by many days march across waterless country; but between Lake Nyasa and the coast there was no such break. From Kilwa to the lake the country is more or less open woodland and early settlement in this area appears to have been greater than in the northern counterpart. The people settled in this area were the Makonde, the Yao and the Makua. All these people were loosely amalgamated in small groups, were matrilineal and matrilocal and first and foremost were cultivators. But the Yao were also traders who travelled over a considerable part of east central Africa. By 1768 they were trading with Kilwa¹ and in 1798 Lacerda observed that in the Wisa country of the Congo watershed all the dry goods had been brought in by the Yao directly or indirectly from the Arabs at Kilwa and traded for ivory. By this time it is apparent that the Yao had become serious competitors of the Portuguese, as Lacerda goes on to say 'whereas it (ivory) formerly passed in great quantities through our port of Mocambique.'²

The Arabs in this region remained essentially the clients of the Yao chiefs, not their rivals or masters. It was from the Yao that the Arabs learnt of the interior of Africa. In return for beads, cloth, guns and powder the Arabs bought ivory, tobacco, copper, iron and a small number of domestic slaves. With their considerable affluence built up over the years, the Yao soon aroused the cupidity of their Makua (Lolo) neighbours. In about 1830³, the Makua led by Nairuwa, launched a formidable attack on the Yao before which they scattered to the north, west and south of their homeland. It was this dispersal which proved, paradoxically, to be the starting point of Yao political hegemony. Their chiefs, equipped with fire-arms by the Arabs, moving in small kinship groups asserted themselves over a widening area outside their own homeland. Of these groups three were finally to settle in Malawi, the Mangoche, the Machinga and the Masaninga. The Mangoche Yao, under their chiefs, Kapeni, Mpama, Makata, Nkanda and Tambala moved westwards and settled in the Mangoche highlands area of Malawi, overlooking the southeast arm of Lake Nyasa. North of them, in the Lisaninga hills to the east of Lake Nyasa, settled the Masaninga Yao under their chiefs Mataka and Mankanjira. Adjacent to them,

1. W. H. J. Rangeley, 'The Yao', *Nyasaland Journal*, 16 (i) 1963, p. 9.

2. Burton, op. cit., 1873.

3. Abdallah, Y. B. 'Chikala wa Yao', ed. & trans. M. Sanderson, Zomba 1919.



in the Mandimba hills, settled the chiefs Nkata, Kawinga and Msamala with their Machinga Yao.

From their new settlements the Yao continued to trade by the northern route to Katanga and with the Malawi peoples to the south west. In the fourth decade however the Ngoni were increasing their hold to the north west of Lake Nyasa thus cutting the main Yao trade route. Their place was taken by the Arabs themselves who travelled through Tabora and Ujiji and across Lake Tanganyika. In about 1850 one of five groups of Ngoni that broke away after Zwangendawa's death and led by Zulu Gama moved down the eastern shore of Lake Nyasa and settled immediately to the north of the Yao. At the same time the Makua were beginning to press the Yao once again and they drove the Machinga Yao further south-westwards across the Lujenda River into the country already settled by the Mangoche Yao. The Machinga in turn displaced the Mangoche, the latter group spreading out over the Shire Highlands to the south. Later the Machinga Yao descended from the Highlands and settled in the upper reaches of the Shire River and around the southern shores of the lake.

At first the Yao traded peacefully with the Nyanja people who exchanged ivory, iron and tobacco for cloth, salt and beads. The ivory which they had buried with their chiefs, used as seats or had been cut into bangles and lip plugs now assumed a value never before realized by the Nyanja people. The main demand at the coast was however for slaves and in time the Yao began to concentrate on either trading or capturing slaves for this market. Also many Nyanja, having exhausted their supply of available ivory, soon learnt to dispose of the unwanted people in the village to the Yao for the trade goods they had become so used to. By 1881 Archdeacon Johnston describes caravans of up to 5,000 slaves passing through Mwembe, a main staging point and the court of Mataka, on their way to Kilwa.¹ Inevitably even dense populations could not sustain such a drain and in 1876 the Maseko Ngoni moved into the area immediately to the west thus preventing further expansion in this direction. Faced with abandoned Nyanja villages, empty iron furnaces, weed-grown gardens and the Ngoni blocking the path to the west, the Yao commenced to raid further afield into the Shire valley and then on one another. Out of these internecine struggles emerged the more powerful brigand Yao chiefs who raided their neighbours in the

1. W. P. Johnston, *My African Reminiscences*, (1925), p. 127.

same way that they had earlier harried the Nyanja people. To this day the Yao chiefdoms, descended from the brigand chiefs, remain independent of each other and there is little true unity among the Yao people. Later all these brigand chiefs were to be subjugated by military action under Sir Harry Johnston but not before he suffered some severe setbacks at the hands of these chiefs.

But if the Yao became the chief slavers of the lake shore and the Shire Highlands, it was the Portuguese who were active in this pursuit in the lower Shire valley and along the Kirk Range. Prior to Livingstone's journey in 1859 this district appears to have been little affected by slave raiding but in the early 1860's the Portuguese half-caste, Mariano, set up his headquarters on Morambula Mountain east of the Shire-Zambezi confluence. From this base together with a following of local Africans, Mariano raided well into the Shire Valley and in 1863 Livingstone records¹ his forays reaching as far north as Mlanje. In addition, other Portuguese parties were raiding in the vicinity of Tete, west of the Kirk Range and in October, 1863 Livingstone met a party of such traders in the Lirangwe² area, near present day Blantyre, which he described as the limit of the Portuguese slavers³.

The southern region of Malawi, more so than any other part of the country was completely devastated by the slave trade. The numbers of slaves that passed through the east coast ports was only a small proportion of those originally captured; Livingstone recorded his opinion that only about one-fifth of those transported ever became slaves⁴. But this decimation of the people was not the main tragedy; the trade was corrosive to society and perverted the tribal authorities from their proper role of defending society to a predatory function. Ironically, this perversion was induced by those who brought commerce to Africa. A note of despair is heard from Livingstone, 'We are guilty of keeping up slavery by giving increased prices for slave-grown cotton and sugar. We are the greatest supporters of slavery in the world-unwittingly often, but truly'⁵.

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1. W. H. J. Rangeley 1963, op, cit, quoting, Livingstone.
 2. It was here at Lirangwe that Livingstone encountered what was probably the most westerly extension of the Lomwe tribe, in 1859 (C. A. Baker "A note on Nguru Immigration to Nyasaland"—*Nyasaland Journal* Vol. XIV, No. 1, 1961). The Lomwe are not dealt with in this paper since their immigration to Malawi has been almost entirely in colonial times.
 3. Loc. cit.
 4. G. Seaver, *David Livingstone—his life and letters*, Lutterworth, 1957 p. 345.
 5. *ibid*, p. 401, quoting Livingstone.